
Economic Dependence & Autonomy

Building your independence and your dignity

4 psychology approaches · tips — by EvaTalk

TO BEGIN

Building your independence and your dignity

Depending economically on your husband makes you vulnerable: less power to set limits, less freedom to choose. In many contexts the husband must provide fairly — but reality varies.

This guide helps you build, step by step, your autonomy: a matter of freedom and dignity.

YOUR INTENTION

What economic dependence costs you most (freedom, security, power to say no): _____

Dependence makes vulnerable — autonomy frees

When everything depends on him, saying no or leaving becomes nearly impossible: economic dependence reduces your power. Conversely, an income of your own, however modest, changes everything: it gives you back freedom.

Autonomy isn't rebellion: it's security and dignity.

Example

Coumba endured everything for lack of income; the day she started a small business, she felt her back straighten.

See the stakes

How does dependence limit your choices today?

Reframe autonomy

Write: 'My autonomy is my dignity — not a betrayal.'

Takeaway — Autonomy isn't rebellion: it's your dignity.

The thoughts that block you

'I can do nothing without him', 'I'm too old / not educated enough to earn', 'it's not my place': these thoughts keep you from even trying.

Reframing them opens the door to small concrete steps.

Example

'I can't do anything' blocked Awa, until she turned a skill (sewing, cooking) into a first small income.

Spot the block

Note a thought saying autonomy is impossible · a fairer version.

A first step

Write: 'A small step toward autonomy is within my reach.'

Takeaway — A small step toward autonomy is always within your reach.

Your worth includes your ability to stand on your own

You aren't made only to depend: you have skills, intelligence, strength. Recognizing your ability to contribute and stand tall is part of your self-esteem.

Earning even a little by yourself feeds a sense of worth nothing replaces.

Example

By selling her prepared dishes, Ndeye gained far more than money: the pride of relying on herself.

My skills

What skills or talents could you put to value?

My pride

An ability of yours you could be proud of and use: _____

Takeaway — Your worth includes your ability to stand on your own.

Concrete steps toward autonomy

Concretely: a small income source (trade, a skill, a craft), savings of your own, basic financial knowledge, and the support of women's networks (savings groups, mutual aid). Remember too that, in many frameworks, the husband **MUST** provide fairly.

And if dependence traps you in a situation of control or violence, support exists to help you get out.

Example

Mariama joined a savings group: savings, advice and solidarity gave her a safety net she'd never had.

My first step

The smallest concrete step toward an income or savings of your own: _____

My network

A women's network (savings group, circle, friends) to join or create: _____

Takeaway — Autonomy is built through small concrete steps, with support.

Key takeaways

- Dependence makes vulnerable; autonomy frees.
- Autonomy isn't rebellion, it's your dignity.
- A small step toward autonomy is always within reach.
- Your worth includes your ability to stand on your own.
- Aim for your own income, savings, financial basics.
- Lean on women's networks (savings groups, mutual aid).

Your turn

Dependence

What it costs me	The blocking thought

My autonomy

My skill	My first step / my network

YOUR JOURNEY

Your 4-week plan

Week 1

See what dependence costs me.

Week 2

Reframe 'autonomy is impossible'.

Week 3

Recognize my skills and pride.

Week 4

Take a first step, join a network.

YOUR PLAN

Your action plan

My 'a small step is within reach' line:

The skill I put to value:

My first step / my women's network:

Your autonomy is your freedom and dignity — you can build it.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool — not therapy, and it judges no way of life or belief. If your situation is imposed, controlling or violent, your wellbeing and safety come first: a professional or an organization can help. In a very hard time, reach out to a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.